YAMINI REDDY, 43
Kuchipudi exponent, choreographer and educator
Hyderabad

Interpreter of Kuchipudi



She may have been born into India's first family of dance, to Kuchipudi exponents Dr Raja and Radha Reddy, but Yamini Reddy had a normal childhood. She can't recall feeling any pressure of carrying forward her parents' dance legacy, but she was set upon being a Kuchipudi dancer since childhood. She debuted on stage with her parents at the age of three. When the sitar virtuoso Pandit Ravi Shankar saw her perform as a young girl, he was mesmerised.

Yamini is known as the torchbearer of change and believes that an art form can grow only through innovation and exploration, but without digressing from its traditional structures. Conveyed through modern choreography techniques, her performances express a new language for Kuchipudi. The lights, sound effects, stage set-up and musical compositions leave the audience spellbound, the unique storytelling transports them to another realm. As her performance last year in Hyderabad did, when Yamini and her troupe of 25 dancers presented *Surya - Tvam Suryam Pranamamyaham*, tracing the emergence of light through Kuchipudi.

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Infusing a modern edge to Kuchipudi, Yamini Reddy has expanded the scope of her dance school, Natya Tarangini, and won the World Dance Day Award 2026

As founder-director of Natya Tarangini, the dance and music school she established in Hyderabad in 2007, she says Kuchipudi demands intense concentration, mental resilience and perseverance. The discipline has, in turn, instilled in her patience and self-discipline. Yamini considers her parents and gurus to be her role models and calls the legendary classical dancer Yamini Krishnamurthy her biggest inspiration in life. ■

— Shelly Anand

HER TAKE

Being a mother to a 14-year-old son and a working professional, Yamini knows how tough it is for women to balance family and work. But she refuses to think that women can't have both. "Women have the tendency and instinct to put others first and not think about themselves, but I feel it's perfectly fine to be a little selfish and prioritise their own needs and dreams"

Photograph by **SHREYAS ASODHA**